attended by Governor NWFP, Sir George Cunningham, the Political Agent to the Governor of Baluchistan, the British consul at Kabul and senior military and civil officers. A unanimous decision was reached to replace regular troops in all tribal areas with scouts and *khassadars*. It was to be a gradual withdrawal in five phases and to be completed over a course of two years. It was against this background that the Pishin Scouts were raised, and a decision was also made to raise the Central Waziristan Scouts and to retrain the Malakand Battalion. The Khyber Rifles was re-raised on 26 April 1946.[6] The recruiting pool was to be drawn from the wartime-raised Afridi Battalion. Lt. Col. Muhammad Sharif Khan, aka Sharifo (5/10 Baluch Regiment), was appointed the Commandant of the Khyber Rifles. *Khassadars* were to be trained and disciplined, in order to make them a reliable partner of the scouts. To achieve this objective, in 1946, a new position called District Officer-in-charge was created to take charge of *khassadars*. In 1946, in north Waziristan, about 2,000 *khassadars* were put under the command of the new District Officer, Frank Leeson.

On 23 July 1947, the General Officer Commanding of the Northern Command, Lt. Gen. Sir Frank Messervy issued orders for reconstitution of his command. This plan involved the removal of 14 battalions deployed on frontier defence. Four battalions of the Zhob Brigade were also withdrawn and levies took their place. Three battalions from the Tal Brigade were removed and replaced by Frontier Scouts and *khassadars*. Four battalions from the Gardal Brigade were to be withdrawn in two phases: on 15 August and on 1 October 1947. One battalion stationed at Malakand was removed earlier in July 1947. The Wana and Kohat brigades were also reduced in size. The decision of the gradual withdrawal of Indian Army troops from the frontier was made by Field Marshal Auchinleck, long before the Partition of India and the process was already underway at the time of independence.[7]

Was Auchinleck making these significant changes at the behest of Lord Ismay, who was then Chief Military Advisor to Churchill? Both Ismay and Auchinleck were fluent in Punjabi and no British officer would have thought of tapping into their phone calls or conversations. The proof that